STEVE NELSON II

ART DIRECTOR & ILLUSTRATOR — ENVIRONMENT & CONCEPT ART

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SUMMARY

25-year game-industry art veteran and art director across two shipped MMOs and a new-IP AAA. Career sequence: Warhammer Online (BioWare Mythic) → The Elder Scrolls Online (ZeniMax Online Studios) → environment art direction on an unannounced AAA IP at Microsoft. Deep bench in modular kit design, worldbuilding, lighting, and leading and mentoring art teams, including directing external vendors across a global network. Now founder of Swamp Shell Industries, producing creature, character, and environment art for games and publishing.

EXPERIENCE

Founder / Illustrator — Swamp Shell Industries LLC, Bel Air, MD

2025–Present

- Original creature and character illustration for publishing, collector's editions, and licensing — ink, watercolor, and digital, from thumbnail to final.
- Visual development and variant creature art for the Extinction Cycle collector's edition, in collaboration with author Nicholas Sansbury Smith (Aethon Books).
- Unreal Engine 5 environment art and world-building — set dressing, level assembly, and cinematic cameras for the Extinction Cycle BioLab world.
- Photogrammetry asset pipeline (Sony A7R V + automated capture) and a UE5 procedural "swampification" master-material system — moss, wetness, mud, waterline, rot per instance.
- Building SwampShell Prime, a studio productivity app for desktop creatives — full product design and art direction.
- Client software design and production: Cadence scheduling software (Warren County Summer Music School) and Crew Flow (The Paramount Turf Company).

Environment Art Director — Microsoft (Blackbird)

2019–2025

- Founding member of a new AAA IP team; led environment art, worldbuilding, and lighting across a six-year development cycle.
- Architected modular systems and workflows balancing artistry with procedural scalability.
- Prototyped environment systems in three game engines to inform long-term tech and art direction.
- Partnered with level and movement designers to define gameplay spaces supporting mechanics, pacing, and player experience.
- Mentored leads and senior artists, fostering ownership, raising quality, and reinforcing team morale.

Principal Environment Artist, previously Senior — ZeniMax Online Studios, Cockeysville, MD

2010–2019

- Planned, created, and managed over 12 architectural kits for The Elder Scrolls Online's launch and expansions.
- Built Vivec City and the Vivec Palace, the Seyda Neen lighthouse and arrival area, the Imperial City, Elsweyr, and all Summerset structures via two modular kits.
- Developed the building-destruction system for Cyrodiil with the lead PvP designer; created the iconic ruined Imperial City environment.
- Oversaw day-to-day operations of a 12-artist team alongside the lead environment artist.

Artist / Environment Artist — BioWare Mythic, Fairfax, VA

2007–2010

- Warhammer Online: Age of Reckoning (3 years) — architectural assets and textures, including both major cities; environment art kits and pipelines.
- Managed external teams across EA's global network — direction, feedback, and final asset delivery.

Previous Experience

- Environment Artist, Dynamic Animation Systems (Fairfax, VA, 2004–2007) — environments and effects for government simulations; particles were his first specialty.
- Art Director, Elmer Interactive (Pittsburgh, PA, 2001–2002) — led game art production and team management for commercial releases.

RECOGNITION

- 15 LinkedIn recommendations from managers and senior colleagues, citing vision, partnership over ego, and follow-through.
- Fifteen years of five-star performance reviews across his ZeniMax Online Studios and Microsoft tenure.

CORE EXPERTISE

Environment Art Direction · Modular Architecture & Kit Design · Creature / Character / Prop Concept Art · Outsourcing Briefs & Vendor Review · Orthographics & Production Sheets · Worldbuilding & Lighting · PBR Workflows · Photogrammetry · AAA Pipeline Design · Mentorship & Team Development · Ink & Watercolor Illustration

TOOLS

Unreal Engine 5 · 3ds Max · ZBrush · Blender · Substance Suite · Photoshop · Procreate · Houdini · Marmoset · Miro